

GALLANT IAS ACADEMY
PRELIMS CUM MAINS BATCH 2027
ANCIENT INDIA
MODULE 8
POST MAURYAN PERIOD

POLITICAL HISTORY OF NORTH INDIA

The decline of the **Mauryan Empire** led to the rise of **many regional kingdoms** in **different parts of the country**. At the same time, invasions from **Central Asia** and **Western China** took place. They were **Indo-Greeks**, the **Scythians or the Shakas**, the **Parthians** or the **Pahlavas and the Kushanas**. It was through such political processes that India came in closer contact with the central Asian politics and culture.

THE SUNGA DYNASTY (185-73/72 BC): The founder of Sunga dynasty was **Pushyamitra Sunga**, the **commander in chief of Brihadratha**, the last Mauryan king. Pushyamitra was succeeded by his son **Agnimitra**. From **Kalidasa's drama Malvikagnimitram**, it was learned that Agnimitra was the governor of Vidisha during his father's reign. He ruled for eight years. Agnimitra was succeeded by Jyestha. The next important king of this dynasty was **Vasumitra**, who was the son of Agnimitra.

THE MALAVIKAGNIMITRAM

The **Malvikagnimitram** is a **Sanskrit play** by **Kalidasa**. Kalidasa's malvikagnimitram is based on some events of the reign of Pushyamitra Shunga.

The play tells the story of **the love of Agnimitra**, the Shunga Emperor at Vidisha for the beautiful hand-maiden of his chief queen. He falls in love with the picture of an exiled servant girl named **Malavika**. He must resort to the help of his jester and play a **game of subterfuge** merely to look at the new girl. When the queen discovers her husband's passion for this girl, she becomes infuriated and has **Malavika imprisoned**, but as fate would have it, in the end she is discovered to be of **royal birth** and is accepted as one of his queens.

THE SIGNIFICANCE OF SUNGAS

The last king of this dynasty was **Devabhuti or Devabhumi**. He was put to death by his minister or amatya called Vasudeva Kanva. Thus, the kingdom of Magadha passed from Sungas to the Kanvas.

The Sunga dynasty's greatest achievement was the **safeguarding of India from invasion of indo greeks**. they were the invading tribes from Central Asia. The Sunga rulers were patrons of Brahmanism which greatly encouraged the Brahman religion and literature.

KANVA DYNASTY (73/72 BC-28 BC): The rule of the Kanvas lasted for about 45 years. For kings ruled during this period. **Vasudeva** was followed by Bhumimitra. The next ruler Narayana held the reigns of administration for 12 years –**Susharma was the last of the Kanvas**. He was a weak King wholly devoid of administrative ability. He could rule hardly for 10 years. During the Kanva dynasty, the Brahmanical reaction persisted.

AGE OF SATAVAHANAS (1st BC-3AD)

The founder of the Satavahana dynasty was Simuka. **Satavahanas** became prominent in the Indian political scene sometime in the middle of the first century BC. **Gautamiputra Satakarni** (106AD-130AD) is considered to be the **greatest of the Satavahana rulers**. He is credited with the extension of Satavahana dominions by defeating **Nahapana, the Shaka ruler of Western India**. His **kingdom** is said to have extended from **Malwa** in north to **Karnataka** in the south.

The Satavahanas had their **capital** at **Pratishthana** (modern Paithan) near Aurangabad in Maharashtra. The Satavahana kingdom was wiped out in the first quarter of the third century AD and the Satavahanas kings were succeeded by the Kings of **Ikshvaku dynasty**. **The Satavahana king Hala** is famous for compiling the **collection of Maharashtri poems** called **Gaha Sattasai (Gathasaptasati)**. **The Buddhist stupa at Amaravati was repaired by the Satavahanas c. 200 CE.**

SATAVAHANA POLITY AND ADMINISTRATION

Satavahana kingdom was divided into subdivisions called **aharas or rashtras**, meaning districts. The lowest level of administration was a grama which was under the charge of a Gramika. There were also officers called **amatyas** who were perhaps ministers or advisors of the king.

Revenue was collected both in cash and kind. **Satavahanas** kings were the **first in Indian history** to make **tax free land grants** to Buddhists and Brahmanas to gain religious merit. This practice became more prominent in succeeding periods.

The Satavahana kings claimed to be Brahmanas and considered it their primary duty to uphold **varna system** i.e. the **four fold division of social structure**.

THE BACTRIANS OR THE INDO-GREEKS FROM 200 BC

The first to invade India were the **Greeks or Bactrian Greeks** who were called the **Indo-Greeks** in the early second century B.C. The history of the Indo-Greeks has been reconstructed mainly on the evidence of their **coins bearing legends** in Greek and later in Brahmi as well. Bactrians became independent from Syrian (Greek) rule around 300 BC. Around 200 BC, B.C. **Demetrius**, the **Greek ruler** invaded **Afganistan & Punjab** & occupied them.

The best remembered of the Indo-Greek kings was **Menander, (165-145 BC.)** Menander extended his rule upto Mathura & from there attempted to capture Pataliputra, but was stopped by **Vasumitra** (Grandson of Pusyamitra Sunga). **Menander**, also called **Milinda**, formed his capital at **Sakala (Sialcot)** & took great interest in Buddhism. His dialogues with Buddhist monk **Nagasena** were compiled in Pali work "**Milindpanho**" or questions of Milinda. Milinda, finally embraced Buddhism.

NAGASENA

Nagasena was a Buddhist sage born in Kashmir and lived around 150 BCE. His answers to **questions about Buddhism** posed by **Menander I** (Pali: *Milinda*), the **Indo-Greek king** of north-western India, are recorded in the **Milinda Panha or Milindo-Panho**.

Milind-Panha or Milindo-Panho is a **Pali treatise** which means "**Questions of King Milinda**". It deals with the **conversation** that took place **between Sage Nagasena and King Milinda** in the form of questions and answers. Its author is undoubtedly Sage Nagasena, who wrote it originally in Pali language.

NAGARJUNA

Nagarjuna is one of the most famous Buddhist philosophers after Lord Buddha himself. According to Buddhist tradition, Nagarjuna was the founder of the Madhyamika School. Madhyamika School is one of the important schools where Buddhist monks and disciples taught about Mahayana Buddhism. It is said that Nagarjuna together with his disciple Aryadeva founded this famous school and Mahayana Buddhism thus became popular. One of the greatest achievements of Nagarjuna was his work on the Middle Way. He wrote "Mula-Madhyamaka-karika" for Madhyamika School which is also known as "Fundamental Verses on the Middle Way".

According to Mahayana Buddhism, Nagarjuna was born in a Brahmin family in south India and became Buddhist monk later. One of the most important philosophies that Nagarjuna contributed to Buddhism was the concept of Sunyata (Sunyatavada-- the doctrine of

emptiness)). According to Nagarjuna's concept on Sunyata, all sentient beings cannot exist independently thus these sentient beings are without any self-nature.

IMPORTANCE OF THE INDO-GREEK RULE

The Indo-Greeks were the first to issue coins which can be **definitely attributed to the kings**. They were the **first to issue gold coins in India** which increased in number under the Kushans. They also introduced the **practice of military governorship called strategos** for maintaining the power of the new rulers over the conquered people.

The Greek rule introduced features of **Hellenistic art** in the **North-west** frontier of India. The Gandhara art was largely Hellenistic in the beginning, but as time passed the style became more and more Indian and less Greek. The idea of representing the **Buddha as a human being** (idol worship) originated with the Greeks.

THE SHAKAS FROM 100 BC

Shaka is the Indian term used for the **people called Scythians**, who originally **belonged to central Asia**. **Defeated** by their **neighbours the Yueh-chis** (the tribal stock to which the Kushanas belonged) they gradually came to **settle in north-western India** around **Taxila** in the **first century B.C**. Under the successive **Shaka rulers** their territories extended up to **Mathura** and **Gujarat**.

There were **five branches of the Shakas** with their seats of power in different parts of India and Afghanistan. **Rudradaman I (A. D. 130-150)** was the most famous Shaka ruler in India. According to the **Junagarh Rock Inscription** he won for himself the title of **Mahakshatrapa**. It also testifies that Rudradaman I twice defeated **Satakarni**, Lord of the Deccan, probably **Vasishthiputra Satakarni**, but spared him.

He ruled not only over Sindh, but also over a good part of Gujarat, Konkan, the Narmada Valley, Malwa and Kathiawar. He is famous in history because of the **repairs he undertook to improve the Sudarshana lake** in the semi-arid zone of Kathiawar.

This lake had been in use for irrigation for a long time, and was old as the time of the Mauryas. Rudradaman was a great lover of Sanskrit. Although a foreigner settled in India, he issued the **first-ever long inscription in chaste Sanskrit**.

Rudradaman I was succeeded by seven weak rulers. The last known ruler **Rudrasimha III**, who ruled upto A.D. 388, has been mentioned in **Bana's Harshacharita** as having been killed by the Gupta monarch, Chandragupta II. The Guptas then annexed the Saka territories.

THE PARTHIANS

The **Parthians** were of **Iranian origin** and because of strong cultural connection with the Shakas, these groups were referred to in the **Indian sources as Shaka-Pahlava**. The important inscription indicating the **Parthian rule** in north-western area of **Pakistan** is the famous **Takht-i-Bahi** inscription recovered from **Mardan** near **Peshawar**. The inscription, dated in **45 AD**, refers to **Gondophernes or Gondophares** as a **Parthian ruler**. It was in his reign that St. Thomas is said to have come to India for the propagation of Christianity according to the original Syrian text of the Acts of St. Thomas. In course of time the Parthians, like the Shakas before them, became an integral part of Indian polity and society.

THE KUSHANAS

The Kushanas, Branch of Yuchis or Tocharians tribe from north central Asia basically from neighbourhood of China. They 1st occupied Bactria or North Afghanistan, displacing Shakas & then gradually moved upto Kabul valley & seized Gandhara by crossing Hindukush range, **replacing rule of Greeks & Parthians** from these areas. Finally they setup their authority over lower Indus basin & Greater part of Ganga basin. The founder of

Kushana dynasty was Kadphises 1 who issued a **large number of coins** and spread his kingdom east of Indus.

KANISHKA 78 AD TO 128 AD

Next important ruler was **Kanishka**. In fact, he was the **most famous** of the **Kushanas**. He probably ascended the throne in **AD 78**, and started a new era, now known as the **Shaka era**. Modern reconstruction places Kanishka's first year around 127/128 CE. It was under **Kanishka** that the **Kushana Empire** reached its maximum territorial limits. His empire **extended from Central Asia to north India** and included **Varanasi, Kaushambi and Sravasti in Uttar Pradesh**. The political significance of Kanishka's rule lies in the fact that he integrated central Asia with north India as part of a single empire. It resulted in the **intermingling of different cultures** and **increase in inter regional trading activities**.

Kanishka is famous in history as a great patron of Buddhism. **He convened the fourth Buddhist Council at Kundalavana** (present day Harwan near Srinagar in Jammu and Kashmir) in which a **large number of Buddhist scholars took part**. It was in this council that **Buddhism got split into two schools – Hinayana and Mahayana**. Kanishka also patronized the **Gandhara and Mathura schools** of sculptural art. He **built in the city of Purushpura** (present day Peshawar), his capital, a giant stupa to house the Buddha's relics. The building was still intact with all its magnificence when the **Chinese pilgrim Fa-hsien** visited the area later in the early fifth century AD. The Kushana power gradually declined from the early third century AD.

KUSHANA POLITY AND ADMINISTRATION

Whole empire was divided into provinces, each **ruled by a mahakshatrapa** (a military governor), who was **assisted by a kshatrapa**; but how many provinces were there in the empire, is not known. Sources indicate that **Kushana horsemen wore trousers while riding**. A **headless statue of Kanishka** found at **Mathura** reflects the same. A **prominent feature of Kushana polity** was the **title of devaputra**, i.e., **son of God**, used by the Kushana kings. It indicates the **claim to divinity by the Kushana kings**.

CONTRIBUTIONS OF THE KUSHANAS

The Kushanas occupy a special place in the ancient Indian history because of their contribution to various aspects of life. Their vast empire **helped in the growth of internal and external trade**. It resulted in the rise of new urban centres. The rich state of economy under the Kushanas is also evidenced by the **large number of gold and copper coins** that they struck. Even in literature and medicine, India made progress. **Charaka, known as father of Ayurveda**, wrote a book on medicine called **Charaksamhita** whereas **Asvaghosha**, a Buddhist scholar, wrote **Buddhacharita**, a **full length biography of the Buddha**. **Both these** scholars were believed to be the **contemporaries of king Kanishka**. The Kushanas patronized the **Gandhara and the Mathura schools** of sculptural art which are known for **producing the earliest images of Buddha and Buddhisattavas**.

TRADE AND COMMERCIAL ACTIVITIES

INTERNAL AND EXTERNAL TRADE ROUTES

The **most important feature** of the **post-Mauryan period** was the **growth of trade and commerce, both internally as well as externally**. There were **two major internal land routes** in ancient India. **First**, known as **Uttarapatha**, **connected northern and eastern parts of India with the north-western fringes**, i.e., present day Pakistan and further beyond, and the **second**, known as **Dakshinapatha**, **connected the peninsular India with the western and northern parts of India**.

The **Dakshinapatha** was the **major route** that **connected north and south India**. It started from **Kaushambi near Allahabad** and **running through Ujjain** (modern Ujjain) extended further up to **Bhrigukaccha or Broach**, an **important port on western coast**.

The Dakshinapatha was further **connected with Pratishthana** (modern Paithan), the **capital of the Satavahanas**. As regards external trade routes, after the discovery of monsoons by Hippatus a Greek navigator in 45 AD, more and more sea voyages were used for trading purposes.

TRADE WITH WEST AND CENTRAL ASIA

An important feature of the commercial activities in the **post-Mauryan period** was the thriving trade between **India and the West**, where the Roman Empire was at its height. Initially this trade was carried out through land, but owing to frequent obstructions created by the Persians, who ruled the areas through which these trade routes passed, the focus was shifted to sea routes. Now ships could move directly from Indian ports to the ports on **Red Sea and Persian Gulf**.

The best account of **Indo-Roman trade** is given in the book called **Periplus of the Erythrean Sea** which was written in the **first century AD** by an anonymous author. Main requirements of the Romans were the Indian products such as **spices, perfumes, jewels, ivory and fine textiles, i.e. muslin**. Spices exported from India to the Roman Empire included **pepper, also called yavanapriya** (perhaps because of its popularity among Romans). The spice trade with the Roman Empire was largely based in South India. Romans also imported several precious and semiprecious stones like **diamond, carnelian, turquoise, agate, sapphire etc**, besides **pearls, indigo, sandalwood and steel etc**.

Against this import **Romans exported gold and silver to India**. It is proved by a large number of Roman coins of the first century AD found in the subcontinent. This indicates an enormous drain of gold from the Roman Empire towards India. Other important items of export from the Roman Empire included wine. Besides, the western traders also brought **tin, lead, coral and slave girls**.

CRAFTS AND INDUSTRIES

Crafts production started growing in this period with tremendous impetus, as trade and commerce, both internal and foreign, was dependent to a great extent on the craft activities. The text called **Milindapanho** mentions **75 occupations** of which **60 were associated with crafts**. The level of specialization was very high and there were separate artisans working in gold, silver, precious stones etc. **Ujjain was a prominent bead making centre. Textile industry** was another **prominent industry**. **Mathura and Vanga** (east Bengal) were **famous for variety of cotton and silk textiles**. The discovery of some dying vats at some sites in south India indicates that dying was a thriving craft in the area during this period. The artisans in this period touched new heights of prosperity and there are numerous inscriptions which refer to the donations made by artisans to monasteries.

GUILDS

The communities of merchants were organised in groups known as **Shreni or guilds** under the head called **sreshthi**. Another type of mercantile group was called **sartha** which **signified mobile or caravan trading corporation of interregional traders**. The leader of such a guild was called **sarthavaha**. Like merchants almost all craft vocations were also organised into guilds, **each under a headman** called **Jyestha**. These included **weavers, corn dealers, bamboo workers, oil manufacturers, potters etc**. The guilds were basically associations of merchants and craftsmen following the same profession or dealing in the same commodity. They elected their head and framed their own rules regarding prices and quality etc., to regulate their business on the basis of **mutual goodwill**. They also **served as banks and received deposits** from the public on a fixed rate of interest.

ART AND ARCHITECTURE

Art in the post-Mauryan period was **predominantly religious**. Two most important features concerning art and architecture of this period are the **construction of stupas** and **development of regional schools of sculpture**. Idols of the Buddha were carved out for

the first time in this period. On account of contact with the foreigners from northwest, a specific school of art called **Gandhara School** of art developed in this period. It was influenced, to a great extent, by the **Greek style or art forms**.

STUPAS

A **stupa** was a **large hemispherical dome with a central chamber** in which relics of the Buddha or some Buddhist monk were **kept in a small casket**. The **base was surrounded by a path for clockwise circumambulation** (pradakshina), **enclosed by wooden railings** which were later made in stone. **Three prominent stupas** of this period are at **Bharhut and Sanchi** (both in M.P), which were originally **built by Ashoka** but enlarged later, and **Amravati** and **Nagarjungkonda** (both in Andhra Pradesh). **The Bharhut stupa** in its present form dates to the middle of the second century BC. It is **important for its sculptures**. Its **railings are made of red stone**.

Three big stupas were constructed at **Sanchi** in this period. The biggest of the three, which was **built originally** by emperor **Ashoka**, was enlarged to twice its size sometime in the second century BC. A number of **stupas** were also **constructed in south India** during this period **but none has survived** in its entirety. **The Amravati stupa**, situated at **Amravati** in **Andhra Pradesh** took its final shape sometime in the second century AD. The **sculptures on stupas** are drawn on the **themes** based on **Jataka and other Buddhist stories**.

ROCK CUT ARCHITECTURE

Apart from the stupas, this period also marks a progress in **rock cut architecture**. A large number of temples, halls and places of residence for monks were cut out of the solid rocks near **Pune and Nasik** in Maharashtra under the **Satavahanas**.

The **place of worship** generally had a **shrine cell** with a **votive stupa** placed in the **centre**. This place was known as a **chaitya** and the **rock cut structure** used as the **residence for monks** was called a **vihara**.

SCHOOLS OF SCULPTURAL ART

The first century witnessed the **division of Buddhism in two parts, Hinayana and Mahayana**. **Mahayana Buddhism** encouraged **Buddha's worship as a god in human form**. As a result a large number of Buddha images were built in different regions. There were **three major schools of sculptural art** which developed in this period. These were: **Mathura school of art, Gandhara School of art and Amravati school of art**.

GANDHARA SCHOOL OF ART

The **Gandhara region** was situated in the northwestern part of the Indian Subcontinent. This region was successively **ruled by the Greeks, Mauryas, Sungas, Shakas, and Kushanas** for many centuries. **The school of art** which developed here around the **beginning of the Christian era** has been called variously as **Graeco-Roman, Indo Greek or Graeco-Buddhist**. This is perhaps because this **school has all the influences-Roman, Greek and Indian**. The theme of sculptures is predominantly Buddhist but their style is Greek. **The chief patrons of Gandhara art were the Shakas and Kushanas**.

GREEK ROMAN INFLUENCE

The **stone** used for **making idols of Buddha and Bodhisattava** was predominantly **blue-grey schist**. **Chief characteristics of Gandhara school of art** lies in its **beautiful portrayal of human figures with distinguished muscles of the body**. Gandharan art is of Greco-Roman origin, combined with Indian artistic traditions. Gandharan sculptures show strong Greek influences in the depiction of a 'man-god' and of wavy hair, sandals and extensive drapery. The depiction of Buddha as a 'man-god' in Gandharan sculpture is believed to be inspired from Greek mythology. Some examples of Gandharan art depict both Buddha and the Greek god, Hercules. Stucco plaster, which was commonly observed in

Greek art, was widely used in Gandharan artwork for the decoration of monastic and cult buildings.

Gandhara art developed in **Pakistan; Afghanistan; India**; is an **excellent combination** of both **greek and Roman influences**. The legendary interpretation of Buddha is sometimes presented through roman motifs like triton. In artistic interpretation; Buddha of Gandhar is sometimes presented through Roman art techniques using vine scroll; cherub wearing Garland. The tradition of representation of Buddha in human form is inspired from **roman anthropomorphic tradition**. The outer robe of Buddha of Gandhar like **kaaya; antarvasa** resembles to **attire of roman gods**. Thus, Gandharan sculpture combines both Greek and Roman artistic influences with Indian aesthetics.

GANDHARA ARCHITECTURE

(a) Buddhist Monasteries: A very large number of Buddhist monasteries were built in the early countries of the **Christian era**. Ruins of about **15 monasteries** have been found in the neighbourhood of Peshawar and Rawalpindi, while in the Kabul valley alone there are some 50 examples.

(b) Buddhist Stupas: The **Graeco – Roman** architectural impact modified the structure of the ‘**stupa**’. The orthodox Indian design of the ‘**stupa**’ was developed into an **architectural composition of fine proportions and character**. The height of the ‘stupa’ was raised enormously by **elevating it on a high platform** and by elongating its main body upwards. Besides, **plastic ornamentation** was added to the structure of the ‘stupa’. All this provided the ‘stupa’ effective and colourful appearance.

SIGNIFICANCE

The main theme of Gandhara school can be said to be the **new form of Buddhism, viz. Mahayanism** and its most important contribution was the **evolution of an image the Buddha**.

MATHURA SCHOOL

- 1. Period and Place:** The school of art that developed at Mathura (U.P) has been called the ‘**Mathura School**’. Its origin has been traced back to the middle of the **2nd century BC**, but it was only in the 1st century AD that its genuine progress began. The artists of Mathura used the spotted red sandstone for making images.
- 2. Its Relationship with Other Schools:** Through the Mathura school owed much to the earlier Indian traditions (Bharhut, Gaya and Sanchi), it also borrowed from the Gandhara school and adopted more than one **Graeco- Roman motif**.
- 3. Jaina Images:** In its early phase, the Mathura school was probably inspired by Jainism as we find that many figures of cross-legged naked ‘**tirthankaras**’ in meditation were carved by **Mathura craftsmen**.
- 4. Buddhist Images:** The early Buddhas and Bodhisattvas of the Mathura school are fleshy figures with little spirituality about them, but later they developed in **grace and religious feeling**. The attempt to display **spiritual strength by a circle** behind the faces of the images, in fact, began with the Mathura school.
- 5. Brahmanical Images:** The Mathura artists also carved cut images of Brahmanical divinities. Popular Brahmanical gods, **Siva and Vishnu**, were represented alone and sometimes with their consorts, **Parvati and Lakshmi** respectively. Images of many other Brahmanical deities were also faithfully executed in stone.
- 6. Female Figures:** The most striking remains are the beautiful female figures of **Yaksinis, Naginis and Apsaras**. These richly jewelled ladies stand in pert attitudes remains of the Indus dancing girl.
- 7. Royal Statues:** Most of the Kushana royal statues were found at the village of **Mat (near Mathura)**, where the Kushana kings had a winter palace, with a chapel in which the memory of former monarchs and princes was revered. Almost all the figures have been

broken by the rulers of the succeeding dynasties, and that of the **great Kanishka**, the most striking of the statues, unfortunately lacks its head.

AMRAVATI SCHOOL OF ART

The **Amravati school of art** flourished in the region of **Andhra Pradesh** between the lower valleys of **rivers Krishna** and Godavari. The main patrons of this art form were the **Satavahans** but it carried on even later, patronized by their successor **Ikshavaku rulers**. This art is said to have flourished between **150 BC and 350 AD**. Sculptures of this school are mainly found on the railings, plinths and other parts of stupas. The thematic representations include the stories from the life of the Buddha.

An important characteristic of the Amravati school is the '**narrative art**'. The medallions were carved in such a manner that they depict an incident in a natural way. For example one medallion depicts a whole story of '**taming of an elephant by the Buddha**'. Another important feature of Amravati art is the **use of white marble like stone to carve out the figures**. There is prominence of human figures rather than of nature.

THE SANGAM AGE

The Sangam Age constitutes an important chapter in the **history of South India**. According to Tamil legends, there existed three **Sangams (Academy of Tamil poets)** in ancient Tamil Nadu popularly called **Muchchangam**. These Sangams flourished under the royal patronage of the **Pandys**.

The first Sangam, held at Then Madurai, was attended by gods and legendary sages but no literary work of this Sangam was available. The second Sangam was held at Kapadapuram but the all the literary works had perished except **Tolkappiyam**. The third Sangam at Madurai was founded by Mudathirumaran. It was attended by a large number of poets who produced voluminous literature but only a few had survived. These Tamil literary works remain useful sources to reconstruct the history of the Sangam Age.

SANGAM LITERATURE

The corpus of Sangam literature includes **Tolkappiyam, Ettutogai, Pattuppattu, Pathinenkilkanakku**, and the two epics — **Silappathigaram and Manimegalai**. **Tolkappiyam** authored by **Tolkappiyar** is the earliest of the Tamil literature. It is a work on **Tamil grammar** but it provides information on the **political and socio-economic conditions** of the Sangam period.

The **Ettutogai** or **Eight Anthologies** consist of eight works — Aingurunooru, Narrinai, Aganaooru, Purananooru, Kuruntogai, Kalittogai, Paripadal and Padirrupattu. The Pattuppattu or Ten Idylls consist of ten works — Thirumurugarruppadai, Porunararruppadai, Sirupanarruppadai, Perumpanarruppadai, Mullaippattu, Nedunalvadai, Maduraikkanji, Kurinjippattu, Pattinappalai and Malaipadukadam. Both Ettutogai and Pattuppattu were divided into two main groups — **Aham (love) and Puram (valour)**.

Pathinenkilkanakku contains eighteen works mostly dealing **with ethics and morals**. The most important among them is **Tirukkural authored by Thiruvalluvar**. Silappathigaram written by Elango Adigal and Manimegalai by Sittalai Sattanar also provides valuable information on the Sangam polity and society.

OTHERS ACCOUNTS

- The Greek authors like **Megasthenes, Strabo, Pliny** and Ptolemy mentioning about commercial trade contacts between the West and South India.

- Also, the **Ashokan inscriptions** mention about the keralaputras(Chera), Chola and Pandya rulers to the south of Mauryan Empire.
- Another inscription, **Hathikumbha inscription of Kharavela of Kalinga** also has mention of Tamil kingdoms.

POLITICAL HISTORY OF SANGAM PERIOD:

During the Sangam Age, it was ruled by **three dynasties-the Cheras, Cholas and Pandyas**. The main source of information about these kingdoms is traced from the literary references of Sangam Period.

CHERAS:

- The Cheras had their rule over major parts of modern Kerala/ malabar areas.
- The capital of Cheras was **Vanji** and their important seaports were Tondi and Musiri.
- The royal symbol of Cheras is the "**bow and arrow**".
- The Pugalur inscription of the 1st century AD has reference to three generations of Chera rulers.
- The important ruler of Cheras was **Senguttuvan** who belonged to 2nd century A.D.
- His military achievements have been chronicled in epic **Silapathikaram**, with details about his expedition to the Himalayas where he defeated many north Indian rulers.
- Senguttuvan introduced the Pattini cult or the **worship of Kannagi** as the ideal wife in Tamil Nadu. He was the first to send **embassy to China** from South India.

CHOLAS:

The Chola kingdom in the Sangam period extended from Northern Tamil Nadu to southern Andhra Pradesh.

- Their capital was firstly at **Uraiyyur** and later shifted to **Puhar**.
- **King Karikala** was a famous king of the Sangam Cholas.
- The symbol of Cholas was "**tiger**".
- Pattinappalai portrays his life and military conquests.
- Many Sangam Poems mention the **Battle of Venni** where he defeated the confederacy of Cheras, Pandyas and eleven minor chieftains.
- He also fought at Vahaipparandalai in which nine enemy chieftains submitted before him.
- Hence, Karikala's military achievements made him the overlord of the whole Tamil country.
- Therefore, Trade and commerce flourished during his reign.
- He also built **built Kallanai across the river Kaveri**, irrigation tanks near river Kaveri to provide water for reclaimed land from forest for cultivation.

PANDYAS

The Pandyas ruled over the present day southern Tamil Nadu. Their capital was **Madurai**. The earliest kings of the Pandyan dynasty were Nediyan, Palyagasalai Mudukudumi Peruvaludhi and Mudathirumaran. There were two Neduncheliyans. The first one was known as Aryappadai Kadantha Neduncheliyan (one who won victories over the Aryan forces). He was responsible for the **execution of Kovalan for which Kannagi burnt Madurai**. The other was Talaiyalanganattu Cheruvenra (He who won the battle at **Talaiyalanganam**) Neduncheliyan. He was praised by Nakkirar and Mangudi Maruthanar. He wore this title after defeating his enemies at the Battle of Talaiyalanganam, which is located in the Tanjore district. By this victory Neduncheliyan gained control over the entire Tamil Nadu. **Maduraikkanji written by Mangudi Maruthanar** describes the socio-economic condition of the Pandya country including the flourishing seaport of Korkai

SANGAM POLITY AND ADMINISTRATION

During the Sangam period **hereditary monarchy** was the form of government. Each of the dynasties of Sangam age had a royal emblem – tiger for the Cholas, **carp for the Pandyas**, and bow for the Cheras.

- The king was assisted by a wide body of officials who were categorised into **five councils**.
- They were ministers (amaichar), priests (anthanar), envoys (thuthar), military commanders (senapathi), and spies (orarr).
- The military administration was efficiently organized with each ruler a regular army was associated.
- The chief source of state's income was **Land revenue** while a **custom duty** was also imposed on foreign trade.
- Major source of fulfilling the royal treasury was the booty captured in wars.
- The roads and highways were maintained and guarded to prevent robbery and smuggling.

However, these works are not very important from the point of political history as are quite imaginary and exaggerated. Certain settlements mentioned here have no archaeological evidences and still lots of work remains untranslated. It gives a glimpse of society at that time.

POSITION OF WOMEN DURING SANGAM AGE:

A lot of information is available in the Sangam literature to understand the position of women during the Sangam age.

- There were women poets like Avvaiyar, Nachchellaiyar, and Kakkaipadiniyar who flourished and contributed to **Tamil literature**.
- Love marriage was a common practice and women were **allowed to choose their life partners**.
- But, life of widows was miserable.
- There is also a mention about the practice of **Sati** being prevalent in the higher strata of society. The class of dancers was patronized by the kings and nobles.

ECONOMY OF THE SANGAM AGE:

- **Agriculture** was the chief occupation where **rice was the most common crop**.
- The **handicraft** included weaving, metal works and carpentry, ship building and making of ornaments using beads, stones and ivory.
- These were in great demand of all above products in the **internal and external trade** as this was at its peak during the Sangam period.
- A high expertise was attained in **spinning and weaving of cotton and silk clothes**. Various poems mention of cotton clothes as thin as a cloud of steam or like a slough of snake. These were in great demand in the western world especially for the cotton clothes woven at **Uraiyur**.
- The port city of **Puhar** became an important place of **foreign trade**, as big ships entered this port containing precious goods.
- Other significant ports of commercial activity were Tondi, Musiri, Korkai, Arikkamedu and Marakkanam.
- Many **gold and silver** coins that were issued by the **Roman Emperors like Augustus, Tiberius and Nero** have been found in all parts of Tamil Nadu indicating flourishing trade.
- Major exports of the Sangam age were **cotton fabrics** and **spices** like pepper, ginger, cardamom, cinnamon and turmeric along with ivory products, pearls and precious stones.
- Major imports for the traders were **horses, gold, and sweet wine**.

Both internal and foreign trade was well organized and briskly carried on in the Sangam Age. The Sangam literature, Greek and Roman accounts and the archaeological evidences provide detailed information on this subject. Merchants carried the goods on the carts and on animal-back from place to place. Internal trade was mostly based on the **barter system**.

External trade was carried between **South India** and the **Greek kingdoms**. After the ascendancy of the Roman Empire, the Roman trade assumed importance. The port city of Puhar became an **emporium of foreign trade**, as big ships entered this port with precious goods. Other ports of commercial activity include Tondi, Musiri, Korkai, Arikamedu and Marakkanam. The author of Periplus provides the most valuable information on foreign trade.

END OF THE SANGAM AGE

Towards the end of the **third century A.D.**, the Sangam period slowly witnessed its decline. The **Kalabhras** occupied the Tamil country for about two and a half centuries. We have little information about the Kalabhra rule. **Jainism and Buddhism became prominent during this period**. The Pallavas in the northern Tamil Nadu and Pandyas in southern Tamil Nadu drove the Kalabhras out of the Tamil country and established their rule.

PREVIOUS YEARS' QUESTIONS (PRELIMS)

1. Which one of the following statements about Sangam literature in ancient South India is correct? **(2022)**
 - a) Sangam poems are devoid of any reference to material culture.
 - b) The social classification of Varna was known to Sangam poets.
 - c) Sangam poems have no reference to warrior ethic.
 - d) Sangam literature refers to magical forces as irrational.
2. Which one of the following books of ancient India has the love story of the son of the founder of Sunga dynasty? **(2016)**
 - (a) Swapnavasavadatta
 - (b) Malavikagnimitra
 - (c) Meghadoota
 - (d) Ratnavali
3. With reference to the invaders in ancient India, which one of the following is the correct chronological order? **(2006)**
 - (a) Greeks- Sakas – Kushanas
 - (b) Greeks – Kushanas – Sakas
 - (c) Sakas – Greeks – Kushanas
 - (d) Saks – Kushanas – Greeks
4. The King Kanishka held a great 4th Buddhist Council under whose Presidentship? **(2002)**
 - (a) Asvaghosha
 - (b) Sangharaksha
 - (c) Nagasena
 - (d) Vasu Mitra
5. Which one of the following pairs is correctly matched? **(2001)**
 - (a) Harappan Civilization : Painted Grey Ware
 - (b) The Kushanas : Gandhara School of Art
 - (c) The Mughals : Ajantha Paintings
 - (d) The Marathas : Pahari School of Painting
6. Which one of the following is **not** a feature of Gandhara style of Buddha images? **(2001)**
 - (a) In seated position, they are always shown cross-legged
 - (b) The ears are shown elongated
 - (c) They are never shown with a shaved head
 - (d) They are always shown in abhaya mudra

7. The practice of military governorship was first introduced in India by the (2000)
(a) Greeks (b) Shakas (c) Parthians (d) Mughals
8. Which one of the following dynasties was ruling over North India at the time of Alexander's invasion? (2000)
(a) Nanda (b) Maurya (c) Sunga (d) Kanva
9. Consider the following statements: (1999)
1. The last Mauryan ruler, Brihadratha was assassinated by his commander-in-chief, Pushyamitra Sunga.
2. The last Sunga King, Devabhuti was assassinated by his Brahmana minister Vasudava Kanva who usurped the throne.
3. The last ruler of the Kanva dynasty was deposed by the Andhras.
Which of these statements given above is / are correct?
(a) 1 and 2 (b) 2 only (c) 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

MODEL QUESTIONS (PRELIMS)

1. Consider the following statements about the Gandhara art:
1. In the Gandhara art the images of Buddha were made in the Graeco-Roman style.
2. The hair of Buddha was not fashioned in the Graeco-Roman style.
3. The Gandhara art spread to Mathura and produced several images of Mahavira.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
(a) 1 only (b) 1 and 3 (c) 2 and 3 (d) 1, 2 and 3
2. "Use of white marble, long legs and slender frames, human beings as central characters and prominence of kings, princess and palaces" were the characteristic features of which one of the following ancient art forms of India?
(a) Amaravati School of Art
(b) Gandhara School of Art
(c) Mathura School of Art
(d) Pahari School of Art

PREVIOUS YEARS' QUESTIONS (MAINS)

1. Highlight the Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in Gandhara art. (10 M) (2019)
2. Gandhara's sculpture owed as much to the Romans as the Greeks. Explain. (200 words) (2014)
3. Though not very useful from the point of view of a connected political history of South India, the Sangam literature portrays the social and economic conditions of its time with remarkable vividness. Comment. (2013)

GALLANT IAS